

IELTS Reading Passage 3

You should spend about 20 minutes on Questions 27–40.

Re-evaluating the Global Preference for Foreign Films

The growing preference for foreign films over domestically produced cinema has become a subject of increasing academic and industrial scrutiny. While this trend is often attributed to differences in production quality or narrative style, a closer examination suggests that the issue is more complex, involving a convergence of cultural, technological, and perceptual factors.

A frequently cited explanation relates to the diversity embedded in foreign film production. Unlike local industries, which may operate within relatively fixed cultural frameworks, foreign cinema introduces audiences to unfamiliar social contexts, traditions, and value systems. This exposure is not merely incidental; it plays a central role in shaping viewer engagement. By presenting alternative perspectives, such films encourage audiences to reassess their own assumptions, thereby transforming passive viewing into a more cognitively active experience.

However, diversity alone does not fully account for audience preferences. Equally significant is the widespread perception that foreign films exhibit superior production quality. This perception is often linked to material advantages, including larger budgets, access to advanced technologies, and the involvement of highly trained professionals. While such factors undeniably influence technical aspects such as cinematography and sound design, it would be simplistic to assume that higher expenditure automatically results in better films. Instead, what appears to matter is how these resources are deployed to enhance narrative coherence and aesthetic impact.

Another dimension frequently overlooked in popular discussions is the intellectual ambition of foreign cinema. In contrast to mainstream productions that tend to prioritise formulaic storytelling, many foreign films engage directly with complex social and philosophical issues. This inclination towards thematic depth can render them more demanding but also more rewarding. Viewers are not simply entertained; they are invited to interpret, question, and reflect. Such engagement may partly explain why these films are often described as “thought-provoking,” although this label can obscure considerable variation within the category.

Cultural distance further amplifies the appeal of foreign films. For some viewers, the unfamiliarity of language, setting, and social norms enhances rather than diminishes enjoyment. Subtitles, once considered a barrier, are increasingly viewed as a minor inconvenience in exchange for access to richer or more authentic narratives. This shift suggests that audiences are becoming more willing to invest effort in the viewing process, particularly when the perceived rewards are substantial.

Institutional factors also contribute to the prominence of foreign films. International film festivals and award ceremonies play a crucial role in legitimising and promoting non-local productions. Recognition at such events often serves as a marker of quality, influencing both critical reception and audience expectations. However, it remains unclear whether these institutions reflect existing preferences or actively shape them, a distinction that continues to generate debate among scholars.

More recently, the expansion of digital streaming platforms has significantly altered patterns of film consumption. By removing geographical and logistical barriers, these platforms have made foreign films readily accessible to global audiences. The algorithmic recommendation systems employed

by such services further reinforce exposure, introducing viewers to content they might not otherwise encounter. In this sense, technological change has not only facilitated access but also influenced taste formation.

Despite these developments, some critics argue that the popularity of foreign films highlights structural weaknesses within domestic industries. Constraints such as limited funding, restricted access to technology, and smaller talent pools may hinder the competitiveness of local productions. Yet this perspective risks oversimplification, as it fails to account for the continued success of certain domestic films that resonate strongly with local audiences.

Ultimately, the preference for foreign films cannot be attributed to a single cause. It emerges from the interplay of aesthetic, cultural, and technological dynamics, each reinforcing the other in subtle ways. As global connectivity continues to intensify, the distinction between “foreign” and “local” cinema may itself become increasingly blurred, raising new questions about the future of film as a cultural medium.

Questions 27–32

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

27. What is the main focus of the passage?

- A. The financial structure of the global film industry
- B. The reasons behind the increasing preference for foreign films
- C. The decline of domestic film production
- D. The history of international cinema

28. According to the passage, why do foreign films enhance viewer engagement?

- A. They follow predictable narrative structures
- B. They reflect familiar cultural values
- C. They expose viewers to alternative perspectives
- D. They are shorter and easier to understand

29. What does the writer suggest about production quality in foreign films?

- A. It always depends on higher budgets
- B. It is unrelated to audience perception
- C. It is influenced by how resources are used
- D. It is less important than storytelling

30. How are foreign films different from mainstream productions?

- A. They avoid complex topics
- B. They focus mainly on entertainment
- C. They explore deeper social and philosophical issues
- D. They use less advanced technology

31. What is suggested about subtitles in foreign films?

- A. They significantly reduce viewer interest
- B. They are no longer widely used
- C. They are accepted as a minor inconvenience
- D. They are only used in academic films

32. What impact have streaming platforms had on foreign films?

- A. They have reduced their popularity

- B. They have limited audience access
- C. They have increased exposure and accessibility
- D. They have replaced traditional cinema entirely

Questions 33–36

Do the following statements agree with the information in the passage?
Write YES, NO or NOT GIVEN.

- 33. Foreign films are always more expensive to produce than local films.
- 34. Exposure to foreign films can change how viewers think.
- 35. Subtitles are no longer considered a problem by most viewers.
- 36. Film festivals are proven to directly increase audience demand.

Questions 37–40

Complete the summary using NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS.

The preference for foreign films is influenced by several factors. Firstly, their (37) _____ allows viewers to encounter new cultural perspectives. Secondly, they are often associated with higher (38) _____, although this does not guarantee better quality. In addition, their focus on complex issues increases their (39) _____ appeal. Finally, the rise of streaming platforms has improved (40) _____, making such films easier to access.